

Candidate Questionnaire

Please limit each response to approximately 200 words.

Candidate Name: _____ **James K. "Kris" Taylor** _____

1. Vision for Technology in Education

What role should technology play in K-12 education, and how should that role differ across elementary, middle, and high school grade levels?

I believe technology can support, augment, and expand educational experiences in ways analog materials cannot. Conversely, people-to-people and traditional experiential learning experiences have been wrongfully left behind. Data collection and instructional differentiation are useful at all levels of schooling, but the use of devices does not need to look the same in elementary and high school. Using devices less in elementary and gradually increasing time through middle and high school is a logical progression as students begin using the devices for research, and producing papers and essays. However, reading and math can both be supported in powerful ways in all grade levels. Ultimately, my vision for how students approach technology is the same for how they approach subject matter; understanding the use and when, where, why and how to use it appropriately to solve a given problem.

2. Student Devices and Classroom Learning

What is your perspective on the use of district-issued 1:1 devices (iPads) in Saint Paul Public Schools? What changes, if any, would you like to see in current practices (e.g., eliminate 1:1 devices for some or all grade levels, establish formal limits on screen time, move from iPads to Chromebooks, etc.)?

Because 1:1 devices in many ways helped usher out physical curriculum I do not think we can simply drop device use. And for many special education devices technology is their voice and their best learning tool. However, I do think we can roll back the pandemic-era necessity of leaning on devices as the first choice. Hard limits may impinge on teachers' ability to make context specific decisions, but guidance toward reduction of screen time offers a good first step. Additionally, recognizing not all screen-time is unproductive. For my children, many of the Chinese materials are digital, but their time is not monopolized by iPad use at school. As for hardware, iPads offer better performance than Chromebooks, so I would only consider switching devices if the company supplying them were more accommodating and collaborative with the district regarding AI policies. In this case, I am suggesting we negotiate future contracts with Apple as a collaborator rather than a simple vendor.

3. Attention, Engagement, and Student Well-Being

How should the district balance the educational benefits of technology with concerns related to student attention, engagement in learning, social development, mental health, and overall well-being?

The district took a big step last year with the cell phone policy. Elementary students will see the greatest impact as they grow through the new policy. I suspect many secondary students had some issues with the cold-turkey approach in which they were caught-up. Watching how

this plays out will answer many questions associated with attention, social development, mental health, well-being and learning engagement. Phasing in policies for students, or grandfathering, should be considered for other technology issues. Consider, for instance, how technology could be used to expedite a student's support during a mental health crisis by providing support staff greater exposure to the student. Or, how a policy might ask teachers in elementary schools to highlight when Youtube is used as a material (e.g., timelapse videos of plant growth). Is it possible to share with parents the screentime of their children without placing undue stress on faculty and staff? Finding solutions to difficult problems is why I am running for the board.

4. Evidence and Learning Outcomes

What evidence or metrics would you want to see to determine whether classroom technology is improving student learning and educational outcomes and whether there is sufficient return on the district's investment?

Current in-classroom technology's greatest value in education is metrics and data collection. Many education software products support both differentiated learning and passive tracking of student progress. These data offer the teachers greater reach within their classrooms to meet each student where they are at and identify areas of need more quickly. Therefore, technology offers two distinct avenues by which student learning and learning outcomes are affected. To answer the question directly, I want to use technologies, often built-in, data collection processes to the fullest because these passive systems take a burden off teachers and allow them to focus on the students. Outside of the devices themselves, I would not place money on a bet suggesting it gets its monies worth out of many technology investments because faculty and staff are not afforded the support, training, or time to set up many of the products purchased by the district. That may be cynical, but the unused "smart board" is not an uncommon feature in classrooms across the country.

5. Family and Community Engagement

What role should parents, families, students, and educators play in shaping district technology policies and practices?

The district cannot shape technology policies and practices without involvement from all of its stakeholders because the discussion is no longer a discussion of tools and equipment. As a community, two separate but intertwined discussions need to take place in order to shape a flexible policy for the future. First, social media use are intergenerational problems such as social media uses' social and emotional impacts, mis-/disinformation, cyberbullying and trolling, appropriate sharing, etc. K-12 students are not the only group dealing with these issues and adults can show true leadership by admitting that we too have to improve in social media use. Second, and in light of the social media discussion, we have to address Artificial Intelligence with the understanding that, regardless of personal stances, AI will be as ubiquitous as social media and exacerbates several problems linked to social media as well as others unique to AI. To say we are shaping a district policy is really to say were are formulating a solution for the broader community which is more or less guidance, but will be formally followed in schools.

6. Accountability and Oversight

As a School Board member, how would you evaluate progress on technology-related goals and hold district leadership accountable for implementation, budget, and outcomes?

My leadership style was shaped in the cities and deserts of Iraq. So I see the role more as a way to raise up and ensure the district is successful rather than a role of simply holding people accountable. I coach little league baseball the same way. Therefore, I would evaluate progress and hold district leadership accountable for implementation, budget, and outcomes by supporting them by any appropriate means. Making connections, building relationships, championing successes and working through difficulties these are all things I can and would do as a board member. While organizational structure may set the board apart from the district, it does not wholly prevent active participation in the success of the district.

7. Artificial Intelligence

As artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies become increasingly available to students and educators, what principles should guide district decisions about their use? Do you support a moratorium on generative AI in Saint Paul Public Schools while the district undertakes a full review?

First and foremost, I do not support a moratorium on generative AI in SPPS because abstinence in these situations has never been helpful to those students most impacted. Secondary students deserve to have meaningful educational experiences and discussions about this technology now. Psychologically a moratorium sounds good, but technologies and the concerns associated with them will both be there and need to be addressed. It signals an opposition to rather than a collaborative stance with technology companies. There are many grievances with technology companies and many of those grievances are justifiable. Identifying companies with which the district can work collaboratively on the vision we have for artificial intelligence in our schools and building that program together seems to me more productive over the long run. And it does not need to be limited to just the district. Greater MSP has a complex economy and networks of experts with which to include. How this district works through the issue can be mutually beneficial to multiple entities; especially the students. Framing this particular issue as a research opportunity rather than a problem reshapes the roles students play as they become active members of a longitudinal research program in which their input and experiences help all stakeholders understand what works or doesn't work.

8. Looking Ahead

If elected, what would be your highest priority related to technology use in Saint Paul Public Schools during your first term?

If elected, my highest priority is not related to, but is technology. In my lifetime, technology has radically reshaped society writ large. How schools function have been significantly altered by technology, but the promised positive outcomes have not been commensurate with costs. Communities have not been in control of the progress. Why? In part, decision making is often dominated by budget concerns and therefore short sighted. Products and software are not contracted for adequate timelines to determine their effect, or professional development is inadequate leading to underutilization. Buying into technology without

training the user is a common organizational mistake. The bottom line is technology can be extremely useful. Technology can provide teachers greater reach and differentiate instruction better. Technology can provide immediate feedback and motivate students. For many students in special education technology is their connection and without it they would lose a great deal of autonomy and voice. However, Technology is expensive in money and, as we see now, foreseeable and unforeseeable consequences. Time, discussion, unity of purpose, and pragmatic steps to meet the needs of all students throughout the K-12 ecosystem was a necessity in 2000 and it is a necessity now.

Thank you for your participation. Please return to intentionaltechnologysaintpaul@gmail.com by September 25, 2026.